Past simple of to be: was and were

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Use was and were to talk about the past (hablar del pasado)
- Choose was or were for each person
- Make negatives with wasn't and weren't
- Ask and answer questions: Was it...? Were you...?

Para pensar

En inglés, «estoy cansado» es *I am tired*.

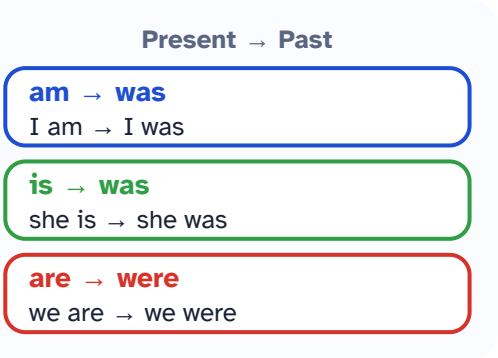
¿Y cómo dirías «ayer estaba cansado»?

Explicación

From present to past

You already know the verb to be in the present: **I am**, **you are**, **he is**, **we are**. When we talk about the past, these forms change. **Am** and **is** become was. **Are** becomes were. That's all!

«Today I **am** at school. Yesterday I **was** at home.» «Now they **are** happy. Last week they **were** sad.» **En castellano:** *was* y *were* sirven para «era», «estaba», «fue» o «estuvo». El inglés usa la misma palabra para ser y para estar, así que es más fácil que en español.



Was or were?

Use was with **I**, **he**, **she** and **it** (one person or thing). Use were with **you**, **we** and **they**. Remember: **you** always takes *were*, even when you talk to only one friend: «**You were** great in the match, Lucía!»

With names and nouns, think: one or more than one? «My dog **was** hungry.» «My dogs **were** hungry.» «Marta **was** in the library.» «Marta and Pau **were** in the park.» **Truco:** si puedes cambiarlo por *he, she* o *it*, usa *was*; si es *they*, usa *were*.

Person	to be (past)
I	was
you	were
he / she / it	was
we / you / they	were

Time words for the past

When we use *was* and *were*, we often say **when**. These are useful time expressions: **yesterday** (ayer), **yesterday morning**, **last night** (anoche), **last week**, **last month**, **last year**, **last summer**, **two days ago** (hace dos días), **in 2020**.

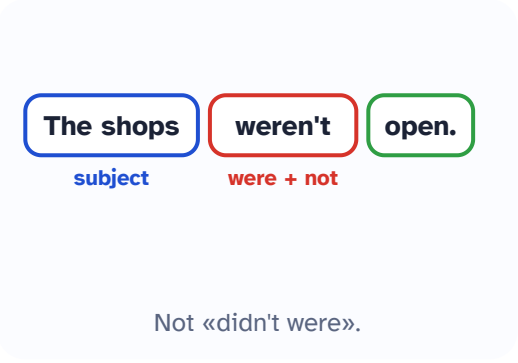
They can go at the **beginning** or at the **end** of the sentence: «**Last Sunday** we were at my grandma's house» or «We were at my grandma's house **last Sunday**». **Ojo:** decimos *last night*, no *the last night*, y *ago* va siempre detrás: *three years ago*.



Negatives: wasn't and weren't

To make a negative, add not after was or were. In speaking and in informal writing we join them: **was not → wasn't** and **were not → weren't**. «I **wasn't** at the party.» «The shops **weren't** open.»

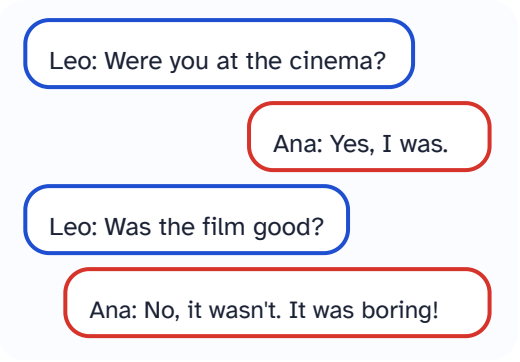
We don't need *did* or *don't* with the verb to be. Never say «I didn't was». **Pronunciación:** *wasn't* suena «uósnt» y *weren't*, «uérnt». Practise with true sentences about yesterday: «I **wasn't** late for school. My friends **weren't** in the playground at eight.»



Questions: Was it...? Were you...?

To ask a question, we change the order: Was or Were goes **first**, then the subject. «You were tired» → «**Were you** tired?» «It was cold» → «**Was it** cold?»

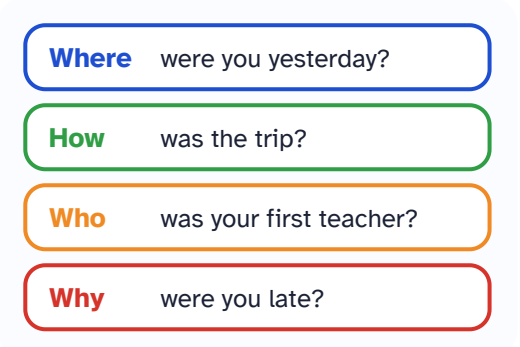
Short answers repeat was or were: «Yes, I **was**.» «No, I **wasn't**.» «Yes, they **were**.» «No, it **wasn't**.» In short answers we never say «Yes, I was tired» with all the words... we can, but it is more natural to stop after *was*. **En castellano:** en inglés no basta con la entonación; hay que cambiar el orden de las palabras.



Wh- questions

We can start with a question word: **Where**, **When**, **Who**, **What**, **How**, **Why**. The order is: question word + was/were + subject. «**Where were** you yesterday?» «I was at the swimming pool.» «**How was** the trip?» «It was amazing!»

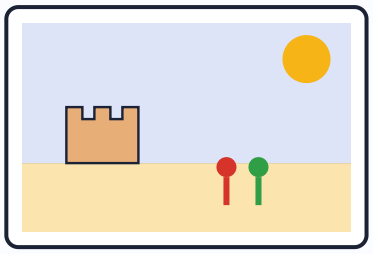
«**Who was** your first teacher?» «**What was** the weather like?» «**Why were** you late?» «Because the bus was slow.» **Consejo:** *How was...?* es la pregunta perfecta para el lunes: «How was your weekend?».



Describing the past

With was and were we can describe people, places and things in the past. Feelings: «I **was** nervous / excited / bored.» Weather: «It **was** windy / rainy / foggy.» Places: «The beach **was** crowded.» People: «My grandparents **were** very young in this photo.»

We also use there was (one thing) and there were (more than one) to say what existed: «**There was** a big castle on the hill. **There were** lots of tourists.» **En castellano:** *there was / there were* es «había».



It was sunny. There was a castle.
There were two children.

Reading: a day at the museum

Read Pablo's text: «Last Friday my class **was** at the Science Museum. The bus **was** very early, at eight o'clock, so we **were** a bit sleepy. The museum **was** enormous. **There were** dinosaur bones and a planetarium. My favourite room **was** the space room. The guide **was** funny and the experiments **were** fantastic. The café **wasn't** open, but our sandwiches **were** delicious. It **was** a great day!»

Answer: Where was the class? Why were they sleepy? Was the café open? What was Pablo's favourite room?

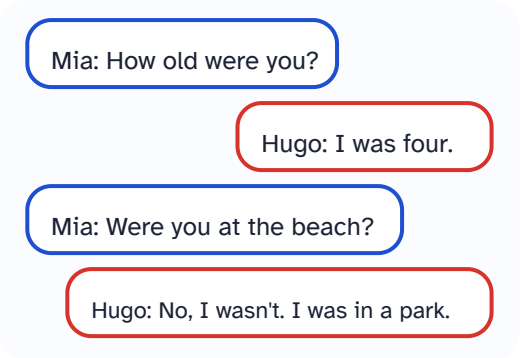
Pablo's day

Where?	at the Science Museum
Why sleepy?	the bus was early
Café?	No, it wasn't open.
Favourite?	the space room

Let's practise: my old photo

Bring a photo from when you were little, or draw one. Write five sentences: «In this photo I **was** three years old. I **was** at the park with my mum. My hair **was** very short. It **was** summer. There **were** ducks in the lake.»

Then play in pairs: your partner asks questions to guess the details. «**Were** you happy?» «**Was** it your birthday?» «**Who was** with you?» **Repaso final:** I, he, she, it → *was*; you, we, they → *were*; negativa con *n't*; pregunta cambiando el orden.



Was and were

I · he · she · it	you · we · they	negative	question
WAS	**WERE**	**N'T**	**WAS…?**
It was sunny. She was happy.	We were late. You were great.	wasn't weren't	Were you there? Yes, I was.

Ejercicios

1. **Complete: «I ___ at home. You ___ at school.»**

2. **Complete: «The cats ___ in the garden.»**

3. **Change to the past: «It is hot today.» (yesterday)**

4. **Make it negative: «We were in Madrid.»**

5. **Make a question: «Your teacher was happy.»**

6. **Answer with a short answer: «Were they at the party?» (no)**

7. **Order the words: «you / where / yesterday / were / ?»**

8. **Correct the mistake: «My friends was very kind.»**

9. **Translate: «Anoche había una luna enorme.»**

10. **Write three sentences about your last birthday with was and were.**

Practica

1. **«She ___ at the beach.»**
   - **A)** were
   - **B)** is were
   - **C)** was
2. **«They ___ tired.»**
   - **A)** were
   - **B)** was
   - **C)** wasn't
3. **«You ___ in my class last year.»**
   - **A)** was
   - **B)** were
   - **C)** be
4. **The negative of «was» is...**
   - **A)** didn't was
   - **B)** wasn't
   - **C)** weren't
5. **«___ it cold yesterday?»**
   - **A)** Were
   - **B)** Did
   - **C)** Was
6. **«Were you at home?» — «Yes, I ___.»**
   - **A)** was
   - **B)** were
   - **C)** did
7. **Which is a past time expression?**
   - **A)** tomorrow
   - **B)** now
   - **C)** last night
8. **«There ___ two dogs in the park.»**
   - **A)** was

B) were

C) is

9. **«How ___ your holidays?»**

   A) were

   B) was

   C) did

10. **«Three days ___»**

    A) ago

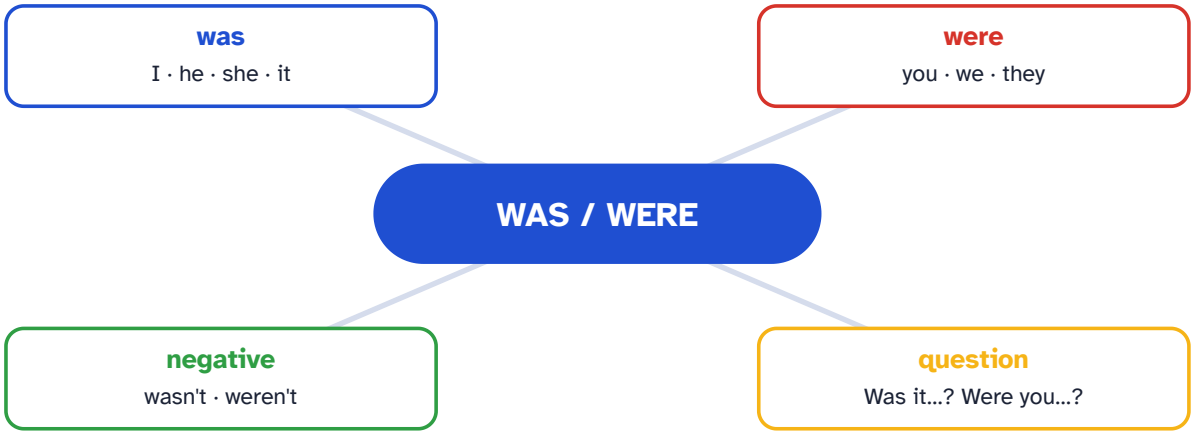
    B) last

    C) before

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué formas tiene el verbo to be en pasado y con quién se usa cada una; Cómo se hace la negativa sin did; Cómo se pregunta y se responde de forma corta; Qué expresiones de tiempo acompañan al pasado.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

was

Pasado de am / is: I was, she was.

were

Pasado de are: you were, they were.

wasn't

was not: It wasn't cold.

weren't

were not: We weren't late.

Was it...?

Pregunta: Was it fun?

there was / there were

Había (uno / varios).

last night

Anoche.

ago

Hace: two days ago.

Soluciones

1. **C)** She → was.
2. **A)** They → were.
3. **B)** You siempre va con were.
4. **B)** was + not.
5. **C)** Pregunta: Was + it.
6. **A)** Respuesta corta con was.
7. **C)** Last night = anoche.
8. **B)** Dos perros: there were.
9. **A)** Holidays es plural: were.
10. **A)** Ago va detrás: three days ago.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. was, were.
2. were (the cats = they).
3. It was hot yesterday.
4. We weren't in Madrid.
5. Was your teacher happy?
6. No, they weren't.
7. Where were you yesterday?
8. My friends were very kind.
9. Last night there was an enormous moon.
10. Model answer: I was ten. My friends were at my house. The cake was chocolate.